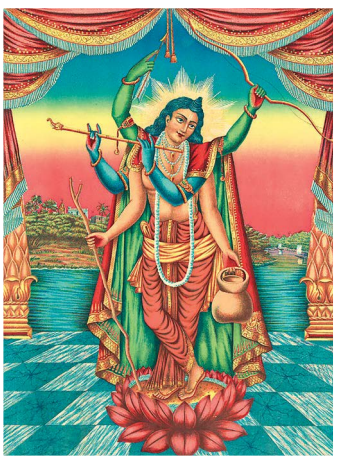
EXHIBITION ▼

DIVINITY IN PRINT

An exhibition at THE METROPOLITAN MUSEUM OF ART traces how chromolithographic prints democratised Hindu devotion





PRIVATE WORSHIP Prints of Vishnu appearing before Dhruva and (left) Krishna in his Shri Shri Guranga *avatara*

Household Gods: Hindu Devotional Prints, 1860–1930, on view at The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, through June 27, 2027, explores a pivotal transformation in the visual culture of Hindu devotion. At the centre of Hindu worship lies *darshan*, the reciprocal act of seeing and being seen by the divine. While this encounter traditionally takes place in temples, it is equally rooted in the domestic shrine, where the sacred becomes part of everyday life.

Before the 19th century, household worship relied on small clay or metal icons. The introduction of photography and, more significantly, chromolithography altered this landscape profoundly. For the first time, inexpensive and vividly coloured images of Hindu deities could be mass-produced and widely distributed.

Drawing on around 120 works from the museum's collection, the exhibition presents the first comprehensive survey of these chromolithographic prints, produced in major centres such as Calcutta, Poona and Bombay, many at print pioneer Raja Ravi Varma's press itself. The images are notable for their striking colour, narrative clarity and emotional immediacy. Deities such as Krishna, Shiva, Lakshmi and Durga appear in forms that are both accessible and standardised, shaping a shared visual language across regions. Highlights include Krishna stealing the gopis' saris, Durga slaying Mahisha, and Ganesha transcribing the *Mahabharata*, alongside Shiva seated on Nandi and Vishnu appearing before Dhruva.

These works reveal the diversity of production, from early hand-coloured lithographs to later photo offset prints, as well as the international reach of the me-

EXHIBITION ▼

MATERIAL MEMORY

Pather Panchali's centenary is being celebrated with an exhibition of author Bibhutibhushan Bandyopadhyay's rare personal objects

A hundred years since *Pather Panchali* was written, author Bibhutibhushan Bandyopadhyay's life and works are being celebrated at the Kolkata Centre for Creativity. A sky-blue boxy shirt is hung against the gallery walls—at least half a century old, it looks almost contemporary, a lot "like the boxy trucker shirts in fashion now", says curator Trinankur Banerjee. For the illustrator and writer, curating this exhibition was a "personal quest" since it led to examining



RUGGED LOOKS Bandyopadhyay's grandson's depiction of his favourite flowers, a dominant presence in his work